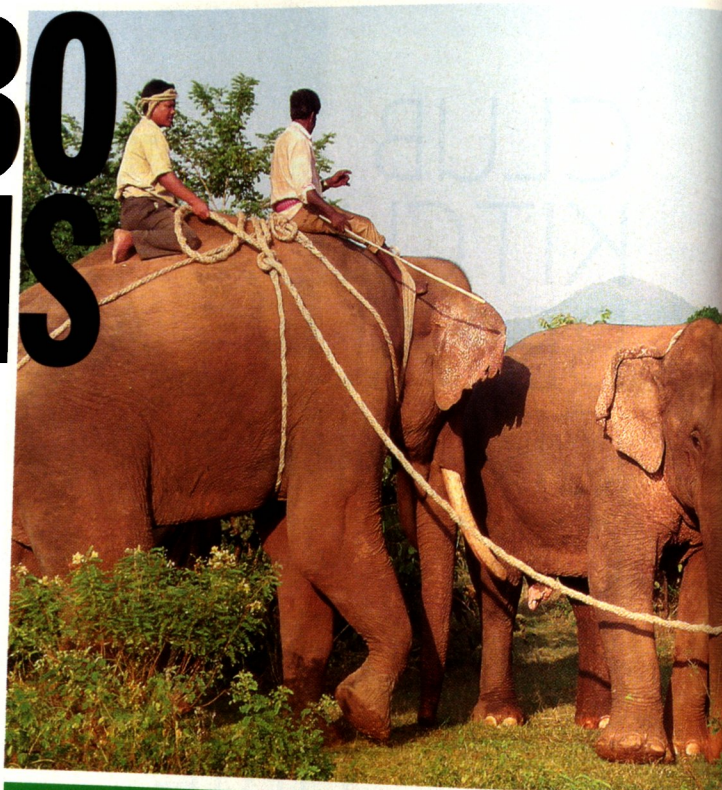


JUMBO CRISIS

A herd of wild elephants sparks an inter-state rift and brings into focus the urgent need for a conservation strategy



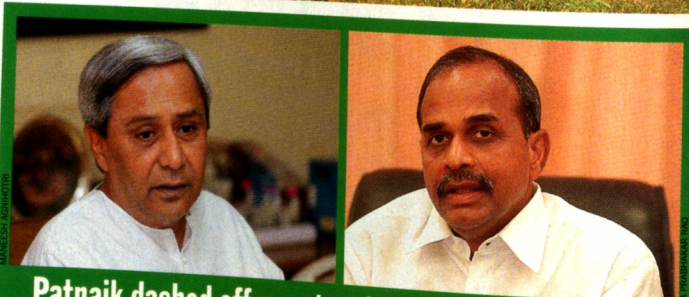
■ By Amarnath K. Menon

An eleven-member herd of wild elephants has triggered a row between two state governments, trapped forest officials into taking desperate measures which killed two members of the herd and brought the man-elephant conflict into sharp focus. It all started when an all-female herd of elephants crossed into Andhra Pradesh from neighbouring Orissa in July this year. The herd couldn't return to its usual habitat, the 274-sq km Lakhari reserve in Orissa, due to heavy rains and a rise in the water level of the Bansadhara river. In its search for food, the herd traversed more than 100 km across the border, leaving behind a trail of destruction. It ravaged crops and killed 16, including six in Orissa, forcing Andhra Pradesh to view the situation as a serious threat.

Seeking a better option, the Andhra Pradesh Forest Department (APFD) launched an operation to nudge the herd back across the border. It summoned the services of veterinarians, who shot two of the animals with tranquilisers. Now tranquilising

and transporting a herd of elephants is no mean feat. The herd chased away the doctors and forest officials when the two elephants collapsed. Following this, makeshift roads were set up to shepherd the jumbos into trucks to transport them back to Lakhari. This plan, too, boomeranged when one of the elephants died after reaching the reserve. APFD was accused of administering an overdose of sedatives and subjecting the elephant to undue stress leading to its death.

Orissa Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik promptly dashed off a letter of



Patnaik dashed off a protest letter to Reddy saying it was mandatory to provide security to animals.

protest to his Andhra Pradesh counterpart Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, stating that it was mandatory to provide security to wild animals in their habitat as well as in their migration paths. A team of two conservators of forests and a veterinarian from the Bhubaneswar zoo was dispatched to the state to ensure that the elephants weren't tranquilised further. Patnaik's objection prompted Reddy and APFD to abandon the campaign.

The four 'captured' elephants, awaiting transportation, were set free and allowed to rejoin the herd. Now,